

CIVIC DECISION ENGINE

User Handbook

Step-by-Step Document Governance, Publication, and Record Association

Version 1.0

Prepared for the Civic Decision Engine



A practical handbook for controlled document intake, review, approval, publication, and explicit association with public CDE records.

Document control

Field	Value
Document title	Civic Decision Engine User Handbook
Version	1.0
Status	First operational edition
Purpose	Provide a repeatable, governed, step-by-step method for using the CDE document workflow
Primary audience	CDE administrators, reviewers, publishers, maintainers, and future authorised users
Scope	Document intake, review, approval, publication, associations, corrections, and quality control

Important

This handbook explains both what to do and why each step exists. The CDE is not a conventional file repository: it preserves independent objects, explicit lifecycles, provenance, verification, and governed relationships.

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1. Purpose and operating model

The Civic Decision Engine (CDE) is a governed public-record, verification, and information-relationship platform. Its purpose is not merely to store files. It preserves the identity, provenance, lifecycle, evidential scope, and explicit relationships of each object entering the system.

Operating principle

A document should remain understandable without requiring its author to explain it. Meaning should arise from structure, evidence, provenance, and explicit relationships.

1.1 The standard workflow

Stage	Meaning	Primary responsibility
Pending Intake	The artifact has entered the governed process but has not yet been substantively reviewed.	Confirm the correct file and complete accurate metadata.
Under Review	The artifact is classified, its explicit contents are summarised, and its evidential boundaries are identified.	Separate what the document establishes from what it does not establish.
Approved	A reviewer confirms that provenance, metadata, integrity, and evidential scope are sufficiently defined.	Approve the artifact for publication; do not endorse every statement as independently true.
Published	The approved artifact enters the Public Document Library under a deliberate publication declaration.	Preserve the public state and publication note.
Associated	A published document is explicitly linked to an existing public CDE record.	Explain why the relationship exists without merging the objects.

2. Core governance principles

Structure before visibility

Publication, access, and transparency do not create trust where the information structure cannot be understood.

Independent identity

Documents, records, associations, source items, and relationships remain independent objects.

Controlled publication

Nothing becomes public merely because it was uploaded. Publication follows review and explicit approval.

Provenance preservation

Origin, transmission, capture, review, and publication dates must not be collapsed into one timestamp.

Evidence boundaries

Every review identifies both what a document explicitly supports and what it does not establish.

No silent rewriting

Published objects are not silently corrected. Errors are preserved and addressed through governed correction or explanatory context.

Relationships are explicit

Context is created through visible associations rather than implied folder placement.

Search metadata is not evidence

Keywords improve discovery but do not prove facts or establish findings.

3. Understanding CDE objects

Object	What it represents	What it must not be confused with
Published Document	A preserved source artifact such as a letter, receipt, email, prescription, image, audio file, spreadsheet, or statutory extract.	A public CDE record or a conclusion drawn from the artifact.
Public CDE Record	A structured civic record describing an event, institutional state, trajectory, finding, condition, or complaint milestone.	The document files that support or contextualise it.
Association	An explicit governed link between one public record and one published document.	A merge, evidence import, lifecycle change, or verification-hash change.
External Reference Identifier	An identifier assigned by an external source, such as a case number, form number, invoice number, or institutional reference.	The permanent Document Identifier assigned automatically by the CDE.
Verification Data	Integrity and identity information generated by the CDE.	A statement that every claim in the artifact is substantively true.

4. Preparing a document for intake

4.1 Decide whether the file contains one object or several

Before uploading, determine whether the artifact should be preserved as one document or separated into multiple independent documents. The decision should follow evidential function, not convenience.

Artifact encountered	Recommended treatment	Reason
Secure email notification with attached letter	Intake the notification and the letter separately.	The notification proves transmission; the letter proves substantive content.
Email reply to the secure communication	Intake separately.	The reply proves acknowledgement or response.
Automated read receipt	Intake separately.	The receipt proves access to the message, not agreement with it.
Clinical letter plus consultation receipt	Intake separately.	Each establishes a different fact and retains its own provenance.
Prescription plus pharmacy claim form	Intake separately.	One records prescribing; the other records dispensing.
Statutory extract saved during a case	Intake separately as legislative reference material.	It supplies legal context rather than case-specific evidence.

Decision test

Ask: “Would this artifact still have a meaningful independent evidential function if separated from the other material?” If yes, preserve it as an independent document.

4.2 Pre-intake checklist

- Confirm the file is readable and complete.
- Confirm the artifact is not an accidental duplicate.
- Identify the source institution or author.
- Identify the date belonging to the artifact itself.
- Check whether a source-assigned reference appears.
- Consider personal or sensitive information before publication.
- Decide whether a communication wrapper and its attachment must be separated.
- Choose a neutral, precise title before entering the form.

5. Completing the New Pending Document form

5.1 Document file

Upload the original artifact in a supported format. File conversion should not alter meaning. Where an image or screenshot is the source artifact, preserve it as such rather than presenting it as a typed reconstruction.

5.2 Title

A good title identifies the source, document type, and principal subject. It should be neutral, concise, and distinguish the artifact from related documents.

Good title	Why it works
Medical Council – PPC Investigation Notice under Section 59(7)	Identifies the institution, procedural document type, and statutory basis.
Doctor 365 – Receipt for Intramuscular Injection	Identifies source, artifact type, and service.

Medical Council – Secure File Transfer Notification (25 November 2020)	Distinguishes the transmission wrapper from other notifications.
Tesco Pharmacy – Prescription Claim Form for Fucidin H Cream	Identifies the dispensing institution, form type, and medication.

Avoid

Do not use a title that adds an allegation, conclusion, motive, or finding not stated in the source.

5.3 Institution / Source

Enter the originator of the artifact, not every person or institution later connected with it. A Doctor 365 prescription remains sourced to Doctor 365 even when transmitted to a Medical Council case worker.

5.4 Document date

Use the date belonging to the artifact: letter date, email date, consultation date, dispensing date, transaction date, or capture date. Do not substitute the CDE upload date for the historical artifact date.

5.5 Category

Common category	Use for
Official Correspondence	Formal institutional letters and notices.
Email Correspondence	Ordinary sent or received email content.
Administrative Correspondence	Transmission notices, confirmations, and operational messages.
Clinical Correspondence	Letters recording treatment or clinical facts.
Prescription	A prescribing record.
Receipt	A financial or transactional record.
Prescription Claim Form	A dispensing or pharmacy claim record.
Legislation	A statutory extract or legislative reference.
Read Receipt	Automated proof that a message was opened.

5.6 Keywords

Keywords support governed search and discovery. Use descriptive terms that are present in or directly connected to the source. They do not create evidential meaning or factual verification.

Example

Medical Council, Darren Smith, C397/19, Preliminary Proceedings Committee, Section 59(7), secure file transfer

5.7 Optional Reference Identifier

Use only an identifier assigned outside the CDE. Examples include C397/19, 004/683, an invoice number, or a source-issued case reference. Leave the field blank where no external identifier exists.

Do not enter

Names, recipients, institutions, descriptions, transmission details, or explanatory prose. The CDE assigns the permanent Document Identifier automatically after upload.

5.8 Description

The description should objectively state what the artifact is and what it records. It should not assess credibility or make findings beyond the source.

Description pattern

[Document type] issued or sent by [source] on [date], recording [specific content or event].

5.9 Notes

Notes preserve operational and provenance context: transmission history, relationship to attached material, reason for separate preservation, limitations, or later administrative use.

Notes example

Communication wrapper accompanying a substantive attached letter. Preserved separately to maintain evidence of transmission and administrative chronology.

5.10 Visibility

New documents should normally begin as Private. Visibility does not replace lifecycle status. A document is not public merely because it has entered the intake system.

6. Workflow transitions

6.1 Pending Intake

Pending Intake means the artifact has been stored but has not yet received substantive review. The purpose of this stage is controlled entry and metadata validation.

Pending administrative note

Initial intake of [document type] from [source], dated [date]. Stored as pending for metadata verification and evidential review.

6.2 Begin Review

Review should classify the artifact, summarise only its explicit contents, identify provenance, and define evidential boundaries.

Required review components

- Document classification
- Evidence class
- Institution or source
- Document date
- Evidence summary
- Evidence boundaries
- Review recommendation

Review recommendation

Ready for Approval. The document has identifiable provenance, a clear date, readable content, and defined evidential boundaries.

6.3 Approval

Approval confirms that the artifact is suitable to proceed within the lifecycle. It does not mean that every statement in the artifact has been independently proven true.

General approval note

Approved as an authentic [document type]. The document contains identifiable provenance, a clear date, and defined evidential boundaries. It is suitable for publication as [evidence classification].

6.4 Declare Published

Publication is a deliberate governance action. The publication note should state what kind of artifact is entering the Public Document Library and preserve the limits of publication.

General publication note

Published as an authenticated [document type]. This document preserves the contemporaneous record, its provenance, and its evidential boundaries. Publication does not extend beyond the information recorded in the source document.

7. Declaring a document published

7.1 Final pre-publication checks

- Title is neutral and accurate.
- Institution or source is correct.

- Artifact date is correct.
- External reference is genuine or blank.
- Description does not overstate the source.
- Notes preserve context without becoming a finding.
- Sensitive information has been considered.
- Approval note is complete.
- The consequences of immutability are understood.

Publication warning

Published document metadata should be treated as immutable. Perform the final metadata check before declaring publication.

8. Creating record-document associations

An association connects one existing public CDE record and one existing published document. It does not merge them, import evidence into the record, alter either lifecycle, or change verification hashes.

8.1 Select the public record

Search by canonical reference, title, institution, trajectory, finding, system state, conditions, signals, tags, or public summary. Read the selected-record context before proceeding.

8.2 Select the published document

Search by Document Identifier, title, description, institution, reference, date, filename, extracted text, or keywords. Confirm the correct artifact where several documents share a date or subject.

8.3 Relationship type

Supporting document is appropriate where the artifact supports, contextualises, transmits, acknowledges, or supplies reference material to the public record.

8.4 Public label

The public label is a short reader-facing description of the relationship. It should be immediately understandable.

Document function	Recommended public label
Clinical or pharmacy artifact	Supporting Clinical Evidence
Email or letter	Supporting Correspondence
Secure transfer wrapper	Secure transmission notification
Read receipt	Encrypted email read receipt
Acknowledgement reply	Acknowledgement of Medical Council correspondence
Procedural notice	Medical Council investigation notice
Statutory extract	Statutory legislative reference

8.5 Public note

The public note explains why the relationship exists. It should identify the document function and preserve the evidential boundary of both objects.

Public note pattern

Documents [specific event or function] within the [record] chronology and preserves its contextual relationship to the public record without extending the evidential scope of either object.

8.6 Administrative note

The administrative note records the governance reason for the association, chronological role, related artifacts, and any boundary that future administrators should understand.

Administrative note pattern

Associated with [record reference] as [role]. This document [specific function]. The association preserves provenance, chronology, and evidential boundaries without altering the lifecycle or verification state of either object.

9. Communication wrappers, attachments, replies, and receipts

9.1 Recommended sequence

1. Intake the secure email or transmission wrapper first.
2. Intake the attached substantive letter separately.
3. Intake any reply separately.
4. Intake any automated read receipt separately.
5. Publish each object through its own lifecycle.
6. Associate each object independently with the relevant public record.

9.2 What each object proves

Object	What it establishes	What it does not establish
Secure transfer notification	Sender, recipient, transmission time, secure method, existence of attachment.	The contents or correctness of the attached letter.
Attached official letter	The substantive administrative or procedural content.	That the recipient opened or accepted it.
Reply	Acknowledgement, response, or continued communication.	Agreement with every part of the source message unless expressly stated.
Read receipt	That the intended recipient opened the message.	Agreement, action, or substantive consideration.
Receipt	Payment, date, service description, transaction method.	Diagnosis, clinical reasoning, or outcome.
Prescription claim form	Dispensing or pharmacy processing.	Clinical diagnosis or why the medication was prescribed.

10. Evidence boundaries

Evidence boundaries are a core CDE safeguard. A review must separate explicit source content from inference, interpretation, or later context.

10.1 Boundary method

7. List the facts directly visible in the artifact.
8. Identify facts that require another document.
9. Avoid importing knowledge from related records into the artifact review.
10. State missing information explicitly.
11. Do not convert a transmission event into proof of substantive content.
12. Do not convert a receipt into proof of clinical outcome.

Artifact	May establish	Does not by itself establish
Clinical letter	Treatment date, medication, route, stated reason, author.	Long-term outcome or wider responsibility.
Consultation receipt	Attendance/payment for a consultation.	Clinical findings or diagnosis.
Prescription	Medication, dose/instructions, prescriber information.	Dispensing or treatment outcome.
Pharmacy claim form	Medication was processed/dispensed.	Reason for prescription or clinical assessment.
PPC investigation notice	A formal procedural step was directed.	Final outcome or practitioner response.
PPC decision letter	The decision and reasons stated by the PPC.	Whether those reasons were factually or legally correct.

11. Corrections and immutability

The CDE does not silently rewrite published objects. This protects reproducibility and auditability, but it requires care before publication.

11.1 Before publication

- Correct metadata while the object remains within the editable pre-publication workflow.
- Verify the external reference field carefully.
- Check the selected file, title, source, date, category, description, and notes.

11.2 After publication

Where a metadata error is discovered after publication, preserve the published state. Use a supported correction, superseding object, explanatory association, or administrative record rather than pretending the original publication never occurred.

Governance principle

Publication preserves history. Governance preserves context.

12. Worked examples

12.1 Secure transfer notification

Title

Medical Council – Secure File Transfer Notification (25 November 2020)

Description

Secure ShareFile notification from Darren Smith, Case Officer, Medical Council of Ireland, advising that an encrypted message containing an attached letter had been sent in relation to complaint C397/19.

Approval note

Approved as a contemporaneous communication record documenting secure transmission by the Medical Council. No alterations made to content or provenance.

Publication note

Published as a supporting communication documenting the secure delivery of correspondence within complaint C397/19. Preserved independently from the attached letter to maintain a complete administrative record and communication chronology.

Public label

Secure transmission notification

Public note

Documents the secure electronic transmission of Medical Council correspondence on 25 November 2020. Preserved independently from the attached letter to maintain communication provenance and administrative chronology.

Administrative note

Associated as supporting evidence for complaint record CMP-MC-20191202-001. This document records the transmission event only; the attached letter remains an independent published document with its own lifecycle and evidence relationship.

12.2 Procedural investigation notice

Public label

Medical Council investigation notice

Public note

Official Medical Council correspondence documenting that the Preliminary Proceedings Committee directed a notice under Section 59(7) of the Medical Practitioners Act 2007 in relation to complaint reference C397/19. This document records a formal procedural step within the complaint process and preserves the associated statutory context.

Administrative note

Associated with CMP-MC-20191202-001 as primary procedural evidence. This document records commencement of the Preliminary Proceedings Committee's formal investigative process. The association preserves procedural provenance without extending the evidential scope beyond the published correspondence.

12.3 Read receipt

Public label

Encrypted email read receipt

Public note

Documents that the encrypted correspondence was viewed by the intended recipient, preserving communication provenance within the complaint chronology.

Administrative note

Associated with CMP-MC-20191202-001 as supporting communication provenance. This document evidences recipient access to the encrypted correspondence and complements the transmission notification and associated procedural correspondence without extending their evidential scope.

12.4 Consultation, prescription, and dispensing chain

Document	Independent function	Suggested label
Consultation receipt	Confirms consultation and payment.	Supporting Clinical Evidence
Prescription	Confirms what was prescribed.	Supporting Clinical Evidence
Pharmacy claim form	Confirms processing or dispensing.	Supporting Clinical Evidence

Why separate them

Together they form a coherent chain, but each document proves a different part of the sequence and must retain its own identity and evidential boundary.

13. Reusable note templates

Begin Review – general

Reviewed as a [document type] with identifiable provenance and a clear document date. The document explicitly records [facts]. It does not by itself establish [boundaries]. Ready for Approval.

Approval – general

Approved as an authentic [document type]. The document contains identifiable provenance, a clear date, readable content, and defined evidential boundaries. It is suitable for publication as [classification].

Publication – general

Published as an authenticated [document type]. This document preserves the contemporaneous record, its provenance, and its evidential boundaries. Publication does not extend beyond the information recorded in the source document.

Association – public note

Documents [specific event or function] within the [record] chronology and preserves its contextual relationship to the public record without extending the evidential scope of either object.

Association – administrative note

Associated with [record reference] as [role]. This document [specific function]. The association preserves provenance, chronology, and evidential boundaries without altering the lifecycle or verification state of either object.

14. Quality-control checklists

14.1 Before storing as Pending

- ☐ Correct file selected
- ☐ Artifact readable and complete
- ☐ Neutral and precise title
- ☐ Correct source institution
- ☐ Historical date preserved
- ☐ Category matches function
- ☐ External reference genuine or blank
- ☐ Description source-grounded

- ☐ Notes preserve context
- ☐ Visibility appropriate

14.2 Before Approval

- ☐ Metadata checked against source
- ☐ Provenance identifiable
- ☐ Evidence summary limited to explicit content
- ☐ Evidence boundaries stated
- ☐ Related artifacts separated where required
- ☐ Sensitive information considered
- ☐ Review recommendation justified

14.3 Before Publication

- ☐ Final title check
- ☐ Final date check
- ☐ Final source check
- ☐ Final external reference check
- ☐ Approval note complete
- ☐ Publication note complete
- ☐ Immutability understood
- ☐ Public visibility deliberate

14.4 Before Association

- ☐ Correct public record selected
- ☐ Correct published document selected
- ☐ Relationship type appropriate
- ☐ Public label concise
- ☐ Public note explains relationship
- ☐ Administrative note records governance context
- ☐ No claim exceeds source boundaries

15. Recommended operating sequence

1. Review the artifact outside the intake form and decide whether it contains one or more independent objects.
2. Upload one artifact and complete the pending metadata carefully.
3. Begin Review and write an explicit evidence summary and evidence boundaries.
4. Approve only when provenance and metadata are sufficiently defined.
5. Perform a final metadata check, then declare the document published.
6. Locate the correct public CDE record.
7. Create an explicit association with a short public label, bounded public note, and administrative note.
8. Repeat separately for wrappers, attachments, replies, receipts, and statutory context.
9. Preserve errors and corrections through governance rather than silent rewriting.

Final rule

Each object should explain itself. Each transition should explain why it occurred. Each relationship should explain

why it exists.

Appendix A – Compact field reference

Field	Question to answer
Title	What is this artifact?
Institution / Source	Who created or issued it?
Document Date	When did this artifact originate or occur?
Category	What function does this artifact perform?
Keywords	How should it be discovered?
External Reference	What identifier did the outside source assign?
Description	What does the artifact objectively record?
Notes	What provenance or operational context should be preserved?
Approval Note	Why is it suitable to publish?
Publication Note	Why and within what bounds is it public?
Public Label	How should the relationship be understood at a glance?
Public Note	Why does the association exist?
Administrative Note	What governance context must future administrators retain?

Appendix B – Definitions

Term	Definition
Artifact	The source file or object entering the CDE.
Provenance	The origin, custody, transmission, and lifecycle context of an object.
Evidence boundary	The line between what a document explicitly establishes and what requires other evidence or inference.
Canonical record reference	The permanent reference identifying a public CDE record.
Document Identifier	The permanent identifier assigned automatically by the CDE after upload.
External Reference Identifier	A source-assigned identifier preserved separately from the CDE identifier.
Publication declaration	The deliberate transition making an approved document publicly accessible.
Association	A governed, explicit relationship between a public record and a published document.

CIVIC DECISION ENGINE

Trust begins with structure.